

One particularly cold Saturday in January, I was supposed to take our dog out for a walk, but it was so cold that I didn't want to go outside. Instead, I just opened the door and let the dog out by himself. I kept an eye on him to make sure he would come back inside.

However, another neighborhood dog quickly ran past our house, and our dog sped after to catch him. I hurriedly went to grab my coat so I could follow my dog, and then I rushed outside. Unfortunately, I was already too late, and my dog was nowhere in sight. I walked a few blocks, but I was unable to find him.

Distressed, I returned home. My mother was standing at the door waiting, and she asked me what had happened. "I know I was supposed to walk our dog," I confessed, "but I thought he would be able to go outside and come back by himself. Now he's gone and I can't find him anywhere."

My mother was very angry with me; she said I should have been more responsible. She decided to help by making some signs. The signs read, "Lost: A big black dog. Please call us right away" and she printed our phone number on the bottom. "Okay, Darrell," she said, as she handed over the stack of signs, "now go post these fliers on all the street posts."

My sister and I grabbed the signs and we posted them along our street as well as along the surrounding streets. The whole time, I was incredibly sad and worried about our dog. All I could think about was how cold it was and how cold our dog must be. My sister wanted to go home, so I told her I'd walk her home, but then keep looking for the dog myself. I took her home and resumed my search.

I continued circling the neighborhood, looking for our dog, but I didn't see him anywhere. I called out his name, and I looked in all the alleys. I got more and more upset. I had made such a huge mistake. All I wanted was to stay warm, but now I was extremely cold—and so was my dog.

Finally, I gave up and sulked home. When I returned, my mother was waiting for me and smiling broadly. She told me, "Our dog came back home all by himself. So, you were right—he did come back—but you were wrong, too. You should have done your job this morning."

"You're right, mom. I was wrong, and, as a result, I have learned a very important lesson today. What seems easy initially may turn out to be difficult in the end. This was a very difficult morning for everyone."

Ever since that morning, I have remembered that important lesson I learned.